

HINDUSTAN TIMES

"THE MODI GOVERNMENT IS MAINSTREAMING AND EMPOWERING ALL THOSE SEGMENTS THAT HAVE BEEN MARGINALISED FOR ANY REASON—IRRESPECTIVE OF CASTE, COLOUR, RACE OR CREED"

did. They are doing two things—taking up the Muslim League's agenda and mainstreaming Left propaganda. *To Left to pit gaya hai, aur Muslim League bhi* (The Left is beaten, so is Muslim League).

Q. This time, the BJP has set a target of *char sau paar* for NDA and 370 for itself. Your opponents allege it is a move to change the Constitution.

Not at all. We always fight elections with a target in mind. We are the saviours of the Constitution. The governments of Rahul Gandhi's great-grandfather, grandmother and father sacked several state governments. PM Modi has never imposed President's rule, except in J&K, where there was a national need, that too temporarily and with Parliament consent.

Q. Another issue that has surfaced is religion-based reservations. The BJP has made an issue of the Karnataka and Andhra governments giving Muslims quotas. The Khattar-led BJP regime in Haryana gave Muslim Jats quotas in 2016, which the SC later struck down.

The Constitution clearly mentions that reservations shouldn't be religion-based. Secondly, if there are some backward communities and they are part of the BC (backward classes) commission's notification, they get reservations as a community, not as Muslims. The reservations provided by the Khattar government were on those lines.

Q. Why has the prime minister said the Congress will take away the *mangalsutras* of Hindu women?

First of all, we have to understand that, for the Congress, minority means Muslims. Prime Minister Modi has in the past 10 years given Muslims all due benefits. What was the need to bring minorities in paras one, five and six of the manifesto, saying there will be special reservation and special treatment? Now, when you talk of minorities, Manmohan Singh has explicitly said that minority means...first fruit from the resources is for the Muslims, he said it in the National Development Council. Now, when we talk of CAA, it is Hindus, it is Parsis, it is Christians, it is Jains. We don't talk of Muslims, because they have Islamic states. They have Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan. But Congress opposes CAA, which means, for them, minority means only Muslims. So, it was our responsibility to